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1 & 2 A bar cupboard or cabinet, like the ones designed by London-based interior designer Shalini Misra, is ideal when treating the bar as a piece of furniture. Misra focusses on bar doors as well as the back of the bar which is generally a mirror or backlit onyx

3 & 4 Standalone bar units such as these by SpeedX Bars are convenient and come in 14 different models in varying sizes between 2 ft and 6 ft

piece shaker, a peg measurer and a strainer. “Invest in some nice ice trays. A 2-inch chunk of ice makes a great impression for the drinks,” he says. Ideally the bar should have six glasses of each of the following styles—old fashioned, highball, stem (copa-style) glasses and wine glasses. “This will take care of most of your cocktail needs,” says Achanta.

Then comes the most important part of a bar—the alcohol. “How much and what quality alcohol you store will depend completely upon personal taste and spend,” remarks Achanta. However, there should be at least a bottle each of a base spirit like gin or vodka. This will help make basic cocktails like martinis and negronis. A white rum like Bacardi is essential for a mojito, and, of course, no bar in India can be without whisky, considering we are one of the largest whisky-drinking nations. “Have a bottle of Scotch, an entry-level single malt and an Irish whisky,” suggests Achanta. You can also have a couple of liqueurs such as Cointreau or absinthe for variety. If you have more space, add a bottle of tequila or mezcal.

Besides sugar syrups and lime juice, Achanta proposes having fresh juice. “Have fresh orange juice with gin,” he says. Bitters are used to balance out the flavours in cocktails. In turn they bring out the different flavour profiles, add depth, and boost the character of a mixed drink. Get yourself a bottle of Angostura bitters or an orange or a chocolate one (perfect to add in an old fashioned glass with whisky).

He also recommends having a small herb garden or just a few pots with herbs such as basil, thyme and mint growing next to the bar. “Pluck fresh leaves and use them as garnishes in your drinks,” he suggests.

Go ahead, get your bar set up and serve guests your signature cocktail at the next party. Remember, home is where the bar is. **BT**

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